TALENT Q

The complete investor and product brief

A grounded proposal for an AI-native recruitment and career intelligence company, from the employer's first hiring need to a candidate's next opportunity.

What this document provides

The business case, full proposed feature catalogue, customer journeys, global market evidence, competitive position, matching methodology, technical approach, pricing, economics, funding proposal, investor return sensitivities, risks and execution plan. It is written to be read, not presented as slides.

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Important distinction: Talent Q is not represented here as an operational business with paying customers, tested algorithms or secured data partnerships. Dollar figures are USD unless specified; estimates and scenario assumptions are identified.

How to read this brief

A reader can follow the document from the problem and proposed experience to the economic case and investment requirements. It answers the practical questions an investor, potential design partner, or engineering lead would ask. It also makes clear where research ends and assumptions begin.

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Evidence standard

- **Source-backed facts** use numbered references in square brackets, with public links in the source register.
- **Product proposals** describe what Talent Q should build, not what is already live.
- **Financial scenarios** are mathematical illustrations, not forecasts or guarantees.

1. Executive summary

Talent Q is a proposed AI-native recruitment platform designed to solve a stubborn problem: finding applicants has become easier than establishing who can do the work, who actually wants the opportunity, and how to move both parties to a good hiring decision. Employers still coordinate sourcing, screening, contact, interviews and offers across disconnected systems. Candidates repeat the same history, receive inconsistent information and rarely retain useful evidence from one hiring process to the next.

Talent Q would let an employer explain a hiring need in ordinary language. Q would clarify the work to be done, translate it into a structured and reviewable hiring mandate, discover people from lawful and permissioned sources, show what is known and unknown about their capabilities, check mutual employment preferences, and coordinate the next steps. On the candidate side, Q would support a reusable professional profile, practical demonstrations of ability, structured interviews, preparation and skill growth.

> **THE INVESTMENT THESIS**
> **Do not sell more AI-generated CV rankings. Sell a shorter, more trustworthy path from a genuine hiring need to a qualified, interested candidate and an accountable hiring process.**

The first paying customers should be organizations with repeated professional hiring: specialist recruitment agencies and small to mid-sized employers with recurring roles. Rather than compete immediately for the entire global job market, the business would launch a narrow role and geographic segment, prove hiring outcomes, and expand by repeatable playbooks. It can be built as a globally configurable product without claiming global distribution on day one.

Talent Q has no demonstrated customer traction or validated Q-Match predictive advantage as of this brief. The opportunity is conditional: access to compliant candidate data, credible assessment evidence, repeat buyer willingness to pay, disciplined AI service costs, and real performance improvements against existing workflows.

2. The problem and the customer

Why recruitment remains difficult

A job posting can produce hundreds of resumes while still failing to produce a confident hire. Employers encounter vague hiring requirements, low-signal applications, incomplete professional profiles, nonresponsive candidates, complex scheduling and limited assessment expertise. Job seekers encounter low-visibility applications, repetitive forms, opaque decisions and expensive or irrelevant preparation.

In a 2026 survey of 2,094 US HR professionals, SHRM reported that 68% found full-time recruitment difficult, and 41% were training existing employees for hard-to-fill roles. This is survey evidence of the problem, not proof that Talent Q can solve it. [03]

Greenhouse reported in October 2026 that 81% of surveyed US candidates had been rejected without speaking to anyone at the company, while 45% of respondents who had interviewed reported employer ghosting. The multi-country survey included more than 2,800 job seekers, but the quoted percentages refer to the reported US groups. [04]

The four primary customers

Occasional employer. A founder or manager who hires infrequently and needs help defining a role, assessing people and keeping the process moving without employing a full recruitment team.

Recurring employer. An HR or talent-acquisition team hiring multiple roles each quarter, seeking better candidate evidence and less administrative work without necessarily replacing its ATS.

Recruitment agency. A recruiter managing multiple clients and candidates. The product must respect client separation, authorization to represent candidates, placement attribution and repeat sourcing workflows.

Candidate. A graduate, experienced employee, career switcher or specialist who wants opportunities appropriate to their abilities, pay expectations, location and career ambitions.

The actual customer outcome

For employers, the unit of value is not a profile found or a message sent. It is the time and expense required to reach a defensible hiring decision. For candidates, the value is being considered for appropriate work, having meaningful control over their information, and building professional evidence that helps over time.

3. The solution: how Talent Q works

The employer journey, in ordinary language

Step 1. Explain the job

A founder says: “We need a backend engineer who can stop our API failures and improve database performance. We can pay up to $2,000 per month, and they must overlap with our working hours.” Q does not begin blindly searching. It asks which outcomes matter, what is mandatory, which skills are negotiable, whether remote work is possible, and who can make the hiring decision.

Step 2. Build a real hiring mandate

Q writes a clear brief with responsibilities, competencies, budget, working conditions, assessment criteria and approval boundaries. The employer confirms it. If the combination looks unrealistic, Q explains the trade-offs and offers options: change budget, relax location, train a junior hire or narrow requirements.

Step 3. Find people and show the evidence

Q searches authorized candidate profiles, employer-approved historical applicants, compatible partners and permitted public professional information. It shows the strongest current matches, indicating where evidence comes from and when it was last confirmed. No verified candidate found is a legitimate result; Q must not fabricate a shortlist.

Step 4. Confirm whether interest is mutual

Before arranging interviews, Q checks whether the candidate is open to the role, the compensation range is viable, location and working patterns fit, and key requirements are confirmed. Recruiters can approve outreach and review communications. People who opt out should not receive repeated messages.

Step 5. Assess and decide

Q can run a structured text or voice screening, coordinate a specialist practical test, collect interviewer feedback and present a comparison tied to the employer’s original rubric. A human makes the consequential hiring decision. Q helps communicate the outcome, schedule next steps and keep records current.

The candidate journey

The candidate uploads a CV or starts by talking to Q. Q creates a private professional profile from information the candidate approves, asks about work preferences and supports optional evidence such as credentials, portfolios and assessments. The candidate can see relevant opportunities, decide which information to share, complete appropriate interviews, track status where the employer participates, and receive meaningful feedback or learning suggestions when permitted.

Talent Q is not a generic course marketplace. Practice and learning exist because they close demonstrated competency gaps and improve candidates' ability to secure suitable work.

> PRODUCT BOUNDARY
> **A single product for matching and progressing talent. Interview practice, learning, specialist assessments and integrations are supporting journeys, not reasons to turn Talent Q into a separate LMS, cyber range, or all-purpose HR suite.**

4. Complete proposed feature catalogue

This catalogue distinguishes the minimum service required to prove the business from later capabilities. "P0" means the first commercial pilot; "P1" means a near-term expansion after measurable demand; "P2" means a later or conditional investment. All features below are proposed, not represented as shipping.

A. Employer and recruiter workspace

P0 | Conversational role intake. Text and voice input; asks clarifying questions; turns business outcomes into a versioned job brief; distinguishes must-haves from preferences.

P0 | Hiring feasibility review. Flags contradictory constraints and budget/location mismatches; suggests realistic alternative mandates, with reasons.

P0 | Search and shortlist. Hybrid keyword, attribute and semantic retrieval; deduplicates profiles; provides evidence-linked explanations and unknown-data labels.

P0 | Recruiter corrections. "Not this kind of candidate" feedback edits the structured mandate and re-ranks without losing prior decisions or history.

P0 | Hiring pipeline. Track interested, contacted, screened, interviewed, offered, hired, declined, withdrawn and closed states with clear ownership.

P1 | Team collaboration. Role-based access; hiring manager notes; independent scorecards; approvals, shared decisions and audit trails.

P1 | Recruiter analytics. Show effort per mandate, shortlist quality, candidate response, interview conversion, stage delays and cost drivers.

P1 | ATS and calendar connectors. Bidirectional, permissioned candidate-stage sync where the provider supports it; email/calendar scheduling without migration.

P2 | Multi-client agency console. Client mandates, candidate ownership and representation permission, submission tracking, client-specific billing and team reporting.

P2 | Persistent recruiting agents. Policy-controlled research, permitted sourcing, approved outreach, follow-ups and exception escalation across sessions.

B. Candidate experience

P0 | Candidate-led profile. CV/portfolio ingestion with editable professional experience, verified claims and explicit consent settings.

P0 | Opportunity preferences. Salary, location, remote/hybrid preference, employment type, availability and desired career direction.

P0 | Invitation and opt-out controls. Candidate can accept, defer or decline contact and revoke inappropriate future outreach.

P1 | Application and interview tracking. Status, appointments, required actions and confirmations; employer-derived status only when actual integration or consent exists.

P1 | Q interview rehearsal. Private mock interviews by role, with questions, transcripts, meaningful explanations and repeat practice; private practice is not employer-accessible by default.

P1 | Reusable skill evidence. Candidate-controlled credentials, assessment results and project evidence that can be selectively shared with employers.

P1 | Feedback and growth. Competency-gap explanation, targeted reading, practice tasks, curated external resources and learning progress, not a full course marketplace.

P2 | Career navigation. Role adjacencies, alternative career routes, salary-range preferences, alerts and opportunities based on a growing evidence profile.

P2 | Accessible low-bandwidth mode. Mobile-first, resumable forms, asynchronous text and audio alternatives, assistive technology support and clear time/cost expectations.

C. Interviews, technical evaluation and verification

P1 | Structured Q-led interviews. Text/voice conversations using role-specific questions and follow-ups; candidate disclosure, resumable sessions and human-readable transcripts.

P1 | Live video interview option. Optional avatar or human video integration for appropriate use cases; not mandatory for every candidate or priced as unlimited.

P1 | Practical exercise orchestrator. Launch a relevant standardized task, capture outputs, and request qualified human review where results matter.

P1 | Credential and reference workflows. Record what has been verified, by whom, with what authority; request external verification only where appropriate.

P2 | Specialist integrations. Coding assessments, SOC simulations, analytics tasks, language and sales roleplay tools, chosen based on job relevance.

P2 | Adapted assessment support. Appropriate accommodations, accessible alternatives and rescheduling without treating connectivity or disability as incompetence.

D. Trust, governance and platform operations

P0 | Consent and source provenance. Every evidence item linked to source, freshness, permission scope and deletion/correction process.

P0 | Account/tenant isolation. Company, agency, candidate and internal reviewer access strictly segregated and logged.

P0 | Human review gates. No silent automated final rejection or hiring decision; employer decisions and AI advice distinguishable.

P1 | Audit and explainability. Replay recommendations against the role rubric and model/data versions; view which factors contributed.

P1 | Usage and spend controls. Per-account budgets, provider routing, email/SMS caps, interview-minute caps and fraud prevention.

P1 | Policy and fairness evaluation. Routine validation of job-related criteria, accessibility and potential discriminatory effects.

P2 | Partner and connector marketplace. Approved candidate-source, ATS, verification and assessment connectors with vendor-replacement boundaries.

5. Ten representative journeys and their failure paths

These are design personas, not completed user interviews. Their purpose is to force the product to handle distinct buying behaviours and actual failure conditions. Each future journey should be user-tested with people from the relevant segment.

Ada | Lagos startup founder

Need: One backend engineer; no full-time recruiter. **Proposed path:** Role clarified > candidate shortlist > compatibility check > code test > human final interview. **Typical blocker:** Budget does not fit “senior” requirement. **Talent Q recovery:** Q explains trade-offs, suggests scoped alternatives and saves the revised mandate.

Amaka | Corporate HR manager

Need: Multiple operations, sales and technical roles. **Proposed path:** Import requirements > rediscover consented applicants > parallel manager review > scheduling > offer. **Typical blocker:** Managers disagree or ATS data are duplicated. **Talent Q recovery:** Q flags conflicts, preserves decisions and reconciles source provenance.

David | Security hiring manager

Need: Find SOC analysts who can investigate real incidents. **Proposed path:** Competency rubric > initial Q screen > synthetic log-investigation task > human review. **Typical blocker:** Strong resume but weak practical evidence. **Talent Q recovery:** Defer confident ranking; choose a task or clarify missing evidence.

Ibrahim | High-volume support recruiter

Need: Dozens of customer-care roles with tight schedules. **Proposed path:** Batch roles > mobile intake > basic eligibility > concise screens > slots > offers. **Typical blocker:** Candidate internet drops mid-interview. **Talent Q recovery:** Save the session; resume from checkpoint or switch to text.

Tunde | Recruitment agency founder

Need: Several client mandates and repeat placements. **Proposed path:** Client intake > talent-pool rediscovery > approved outreach > client submissions > placement tracking. **Typical blocker:** Client conflicts or candidate represented twice. **Talent Q recovery:** Representation ledger, role permissions and duplicate-submission warning.

Grace | Multinational HR operator

Need: Multi-country and multilingual regulated recruiting. **Proposed path:** Jurisdiction config > local intake > source controls > assessments > approvals > system sync. **Typical blocker:** A workflow is permitted in one country but restricted in another. **Talent Q recovery:** Country-specific policy gate and manual escalation.

Chiamaka | New graduate

Need: First cybersecurity job; little formal experience. **Proposed path:** Profile > evidence inventory > realistic junior roles > optional practice > apply > feedback. **Typical blocker:** Experience requirements and limited financial resources. **Talent Q recovery:** Show entry-level paths, affordable evidence tasks and non-paywalled access.

Femi | Passive senior developer

Need: Better opportunity without alerting current employer. **Proposed path:** Confidential invite > compensation fit > selective disclosure > interview > offer. **Typical blocker:** Privacy risk or salary mismatch. **Talent Q recovery:** Privacy-first interest check; no surprise public status change.

Zara | Career switcher

Need: Move from operations into data analysis. **Proposed path:** Transferable skills > competency gaps > sample work > target roles > practice. **Typical blocker:** Historic title masks transferable competence. **Talent Q recovery:** Use work samples and adjacent skills, not keywords alone.

Emeka | Low-bandwidth applicant

Need: Qualified candidate using an older mobile phone. **Proposed path:** Short mobile intake > async assessment > interview choice > confirmation. **Typical blocker:** Audio/video fails or data cost is too high. **Talent Q recovery:** Resume, switch format and ensure accommodations are meaningful.

6. Q-Match: proposed matching and evidence method

The core matching engine should be a set of transparent services, not one large language model prompted to “choose the best candidate.” Models can interpret language and explain findings, but access controls, source permissions, mandatory conditions, scoring and state transitions should be checked by deterministic code.

Step one: define the role and legitimate constraints

A mandate contains responsibilities, observable skills, weights, employment conditions, approved criteria and a rubric version. The system checks confirmed legal and role-relevant requirements before ranking. Missing data is marked “unverified,” not treated as evidence of failure. Age, sex, ethnicity, disability, inferred personality and social-media lifestyle must not become routine score inputs; any lawful occupational exception requires case-by-case legal review.

Step two: calculate employer competency fit

For candidate i and requirement j, let w(j) be the requirement weight (all weights sum to 1), s(i,j) the demonstrated skill score from 0 to 1, c(i,j) confidence in that evidence from 0 to 1, and m(j) a pre-established neutral prior for uncertain evidence.

> PROPOSED BASELINE FORMULA
> **Employer fit F(i) = 100 × SUM over requirements j of w(j) × [c(i,j) × s(i,j) + (1 − c(i,j)) × m(j)].**

Separately report evidence coverage C(i) = SUM w(j) × c(i,j). High fit with low coverage is a warning to collect more evidence, not an instruction to reject the candidate. Source timestamps, contradictions and assessment quality must influence confidence under pre-specified rules.

Step three: measure candidate-side compatibility

Build a distinct, candidate-controlled preference score A(i) covering compensation, location, working pattern, role ambitions and availability. Each dimension receives an explicit nonnegative weight. If preferences are unknown, present the match as provisional and ask the person instead of inventing a preference.

Step four: combine the two sides

> PROPOSED MUTUAL INDEX
> **Mutual index M(i) = square root of [F(i) × A(i)], for candidates who satisfy confirmed legitimate eligibility conditions. This is a ranking heuristic, not a probability of hiring success.**

Illustrative comparison: Candidate A has employer fit 82 and candidate compatibility 90, giving a mutual index of about 85.9. Candidate B has employer fit 93 and compatibility 40, giving about 61.0. Candidate A is the stronger initial mutual fit, although interviews and further checks could change the judgment.

A shortlist should also account for evidence diversity, source quality, interview capacity and search coverage. Showing the top 15 numerical scores without checking what each number represents would be a design failure.

Step five: validate before making predictive claims

The weights, priors and thresholds start as design parameters. They must be tested against structured recruiter assessments, candidate interest outcomes and subsequent hiring results. When sufficient permissioned data exist, later models may estimate probabilities such as interview acceptance or offer acceptance. Those probabilities require out-of-sample calibration, data-leakage controls, segment-level fairness testing and monitoring. Do not present a fit index as “an 86% chance of success.”

What could actually become proprietary

The formula itself is easy to copy. Defensibility would instead come from a role-specific competency taxonomy, high-quality candidate evidence, permissioned outcome data, standardized evaluation methods, well-calibrated ranking, and trustworthy orchestration across real employers and candidates. These do not yet exist at scale for Talent Q.

7. Technical architecture, AI agents and speed

The system in five layers

1. Experience. Web/mobile interfaces for employers, agencies and candidates; accessible text and voice interactions, clear state, human decisions and transparent controls.

2. Governed Q orchestration. Intent understanding, memory, tool planning, permission checks, task execution, session continuity, voice and provider routing. Q is the shared brain inside Talent Q; no investor-facing dependency on another brand.

3. Recruitment domain services. Hiring mandates, evidence store, candidate profiles, consent, search, Q-Match, outreach, interviews, assessments, calendar coordination and pipeline.

4. Data and integrations. Transactional database, search indexes, document storage, event log, vector retrieval, approved ATS, messaging, licensed data and assessment providers.

5. Assurance. Role permissions, tenant isolation, auditing, data rights, budget caps, human review, model evaluation, incident response and observability.

The agent model

A recruiter can delegate sourcing, shortlist refreshes, interview coordination or follow-ups to an agent for a defined mandate. Every agent action has a scope, permitted tool list, explicit spend and communication limits, time to live, records and a human escalation rule. Agents may propose a rejection, but they should not independently make a consequential final hiring decision.

Interviews and practical assessments

Use a provider-neutral adapter for video avatars and live voice, so the user can choose low-cost text, audio or premium video when appropriate. A technical interview does not always need an avatar. For cybersecurity, a controlled synthetic alert investigation is a sensible starting exercise; for software engineering, use a reputable coding environment; for sales, roleplay can measure job-specific behaviours. Full cyber ranges or IDEs can be integrated rather than rebuilt initially.

Super-speed without false promises

Interaction	Target, not achieved
Interface acknowledgement	p95 under 300 milliseconds
First streamed Q text	p95 under 1.5 seconds
Re-rank already indexed profiles	p95 under 2 seconds
First useful external search result	Aim under 5 seconds where source permits
Full external verification	Asynchronous with source-specific completion state

A new external search cannot honestly be guaranteed to finish instantly. Preindex permitted data, cache stable summaries, stream results progressively, parallelize source

calls and perform deterministic matching outside LLM tokens. Preserve source freshness and privacy even when optimizing response time.

Data model essentials

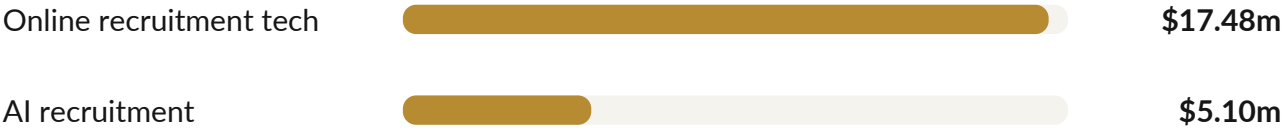
Core entities: organization; role and mandate version; candidate profile; employment preference; competency; evidence item; source/permission grant; verification; match snapshot; outreach attempt; application; interview session; assessment; scorecard; human decision; agent run; financial usage event; model and policy version. Every important state transition needs an event record, not just a rewritten final status.

8. Global market evidence and competitive reality

Market context: substantial, but not ours by default

Fortune Business Insights estimates online recruitment technology at $17.48 billion in 2026, growing to $46.07 billion by 2034. Grand View Research separately estimates the AI recruitment category at $5.1 billion in 2026. The category definitions overlap, and publisher forecasts are not an independently auditable count of Talent Q customers. The figures cannot be added together. [01][02]

2026 published market estimates (USD billions)



These market estimates demonstrate investment in recruitment software, not a guaranteed serviceable market for a new entrant. The meaningful business case is bottom-up: organizations reachable through our distribution channels multiplied by conversion, retention and actual annual account spend.

The competition already has sophisticated AI

LinkedIn Recruiter / Hiring Assistant 2. Conversational search, richer verification, recruiter memory and agentic workflow execution. LinkedIn reported over 20,000 companies using its agentic hiring solutions in its first year. [05]

Indeed. Launched an AI Sourcing Assistant in June 2026, with employer-reported time and candidate quality improvements presented as vendor claims. [06]

Greenhouse. Its October 2026 Orchestrated Hiring Ecosystem connects candidate profiles, sourcing, voice interviews, scheduling and ATS management. [07]

Juicebox and hireEZ. Already market agent-led sourcing, outreach, search calibration, ATS connections and hiring analytics. [08][09]

Jobberman and MyJobMag. Offer substantial Nigerian talent reach, application management, prequalification and human recruitment services. Public prices include Jobberman Standard at NGN 100,000 per role and MyJobMag at NGN 7,500 per job or NGN 75,000 per month for an unlimited posting plan. Features differ. [10][11]

The appropriate claim is not that competitors have no AI or no connected workflow. It is that Talent Q intends to compete on a stronger relationship between defined work, candidate-owned job-relevant evidence, two-sided interest and accountable completion. This must be measured in pilots, since major incumbents are also targeting parts of the same problem.

Where the opportunity could be

- **Better role understanding for non-experts:** founders often need to describe a business outcome before they know what title to hire.
- **Evidence portability:** candidates should not have to demonstrate the same skill from scratch when validated, consented evidence can be reused appropriately.
- **Mutual suitability early:** compensation, working conditions and interest should be discussed before costly interviews.
- **Actionable candidate status:** participating employers can commit to review windows and more reliable communication.
- **Practical assessment orchestration:** the platform selects or connects the correct tools without demanding every employer learn a specialist testing product.

Geographic strategy: global design, selective launch

A global product must accommodate different currencies, languages, employment rules, data locations and candidate expectations. The initial commercial effort should compare Nigerian or West African professional-role employers, international specialist agencies and English-speaking mid-market teams. The winner is the segment with lawful data access, repeat mandates, reachable buyers, reasonable acquisition cost and strong retention, not simply the biggest country.

9. Market entry and distribution plan

The first commercial wedge

Begin with a managed software-assisted pilot for specialist agencies and employers handling recurring professional hiring. Concentrate on two or three role families, such as business development, technical support and software engineering. This reduces the assessment design space and allows a clear comparison with existing recruitment workflows.

How the first customers are acquired

Design partners. Recruit ten to fifteen employers or agencies for detailed intake interviews, secure a small set of real hiring mandates and establish their existing costs and conversion rates.

Proof-of-value pilots. Deliver permissioned shortlists with source and interest verification, track recruiter hours and candidate response, then charge at least a modest pilot fee.

Repeatability. Standardize successful role rubrics, outreach approvals, evidence criteria and support playbooks. Measure renewals and repeated usage.

Partner distribution. Evaluate niche recruiters, HR consultancies, professional communities, training organizations and approved ATS partners, with consent and representation terms.

Geographic expansion. Open a new country only after local legal review, source contracts, currency/payment handling, support capability and buyer economics are credible.

The first measurable funnel

One scenario: 8,000 reachable organizations × 35% contactable × 12% response × 35% meeting conversion × 25% paid conversion gives roughly 29 paying accounts. This is an illustrative funnel to falsify, not a customer forecast. Track every stage in a CRM and replace all percentages with observed cohort data.

What constitutes product-market progress

A good sign is not large free signup volume. It is repeat paid mandates, organizations renewing for a second cycle, recruiters spending materially less time per acceptable shortlist, candidates willing to participate without coercion, and paid accounts whose direct delivery costs stay bounded.

10. Business model, pricing and unit economics

What customers would buy

The recommended business model is employer-funded. Candidates should not be charged merely to become visible, apply, contest an error or correct their data. Employers pay for useful recruitment workflows; higher-cost assessments, verification and premium video are metered.

Proposed offer	Test pricing and purpose
Pilot mandate	USD 129 for one 30-day active hiring requirement, limited usage.
Growth subscription	USD 349 per month for small HR teams and up to three active mandates, subject to usage limits.
Agency subscription	USD 799 per month for multi-client recruiting and a defined number of users and mandates.
Enterprise	From USD 24,000 per year, custom requirements, governance and integrations.
Metered add-ons	Specialist assessments, third-party verification, licensed data and high-cost video minutes.

These are proposed tests, not actual customer prices, accepted quotes or demonstrated willingness to pay. They cannot be compared one-for-one with a simple job-posting fee.

Illustrative cost per Growth customer-month

Modeled direct cost	USD / month
Source licensing and verification	22
AI inference and retrieval	12
Messaging	8
Voice interviews	10
Hosting and storage	8
Direct support	22
Billing and disputes	11
Total direct cost	**93**

At a USD 349 monthly price and USD 93 modeled direct cost, the gross contribution is USD 256 and the gross margin about 73.4%. This is before central engineering, research, broad marketing, legal retainers, overhead, taxes and capital expenditure. Heavy video, licensed data or human support can sharply reduce the margin.

Customer acquisition, churn and payback

At a hypothetical customer acquisition cost of USD 1,100, monthly gross contribution of USD 256 implies approximately 4.3 months of gross-contribution payback. At an assumed monthly logo churn of 5%, simple undiscounted contribution LTV would be USD 5,120, or 4.7 times CAC. But 5% monthly churn corresponds to roughly 46% of accounts lost annually before replacement and should not be treated as a healthy long-term target.

Operational dashboards must show paid acquisition cost, fully loaded acquisition payback, source and interview cost per mandate, support effort, monthly churn, expansion revenue, candidate response, shortlist-to-interview conversion, interview-to-offer conversion and time-to-hire.

11. Five-year financial scenarios and investor economics

The business has no financial operating history. The figures below are explicit models for the calendar years 2027 to 2031, not forecasts. Subscription revenue = 12 × average paying accounts during the year × average monthly revenue per account. Variable hiring fees, assessment overages and implementation are excluded from these base calculations.

Year	Avg paid accounts	Monthly ARPA	Revenue	Modeled result*
2027	40	$250	$0.12m	-$0.62m
2028	150	$270	$0.49m	-$0.81m
2029	500	$290	$1.74m	-$0.53m
2030	1,500	$310	$5.58m	+$0.98m
2031	3,600	$330	$14.26m	+$4.32m

*Modeled result is subscription gross profit less broad assumed operating expenses, not net income, audited EBITDA or free cash flow. Calculation assumptions for gross margin across 2027–2031 are 65%, 70%, 73%, 75% and 78%.

2031 is highly sensitive to customer acquisition

Case	Avg accounts	Monthly revenue/account	Annual subscriptions
Downside	750	$200	$1.80m
Base	3,600	$330	$14.26m
Upside	9,000	$440	$47.52m

The main drivers are successful customer acquisition, sustained retention, account expansion and ability to charge for recurring value. None has yet been demonstrated. A business capable of earning several million dollars in recurring revenue is still not necessarily venture-scale if acquisition costs, churn or valuation multiples are unfavorable.

Illustrative capital raise and spending plan

A planning case of USD 1.8 million could finance a milestone-driven program if monthly spending is controlled. It is not a final funding ask, valuation, financing agreement or guarantee of 18–24 months of runway. The base-model 2027 and 2028 operating shortfalls total approximately USD 1.43 million before cash timing, exceptional costs and working capital. A monthly cash plan is required before formally raising.

Capital use	Share	Amount
Product, engineering and quality	45%	$810,000
Customer acquisition and pilots	22%	$396,000
Data rights, privacy, legal, audit	15%	$270,000
Infrastructure and assessments	10%	$180,000
Reserve and contingencies	8%	$144,000

How an equity investor might earn a return

Equity investors generally expect value through an acquisition, secondary sale or another liquidity event. Talent Q cannot promise either a dividend or a scheduled exit. For illustration only, suppose a USD 1.8 million investment were made at a USD 7.2 million pre-money valuation: the investor would initially own 20%. If further financing reduced that ownership by 30% relative, the remaining stake would be 14% before any special rights.

Using a simplifying exit valuation of annual subscription revenue multiplied by an illustrative revenue multiple, and ignoring debt, preferred return terms, liquidation preferences, taxes and transaction costs, we can show the sensitivity.

Illustrative exit case	Exit value	14% proceeds	Multiple of $1.8m
Downside: $1.80m × 2	$3.60m	$0.50m	0.28×
Base: $14.26m × 4	$57.04m	$7.99m	4.44×
Upside: $47.52m × 6	$285.12m	$39.92m	22.18×

These values are **not** predicted exit prices, valuation comparables or promised investor proceeds. Actual investor outcomes depend heavily on timing, ownership, financing dilution, liquidation preferences, revenue quality, growth, competition and whether a buyer exists. Total capital loss is possible.

What evidence would justify a stronger investment case

Signed paid customers, repeat buying behaviour, account retention, measured gross margin from provider bills, the number of qualified candidates actually progressing to interviews, defensible use of recruitment data, and independent comparative testing of the Q-Match system would be more persuasive than increasing the projected upside multiple.

12. Competitive advantage, defensibility and “why us”

Talent Q should be presented independently. Investors should not need to know about another product to understand why it exists. The future advantage must be measurable in the recruitment experience and difficult for rivals to cheaply reproduce.

The plausible advantages to pursue

Better job definition. Q turns vague business needs into explicit, testable skills and constraints, reducing the risk of optimizing search against the wrong brief.

Mutual compatibility. The candidate’s real preferences and consent matter alongside employer capability requirements; unsuitable salary and work arrangements are surfaced earlier.

Candidate evidence portability. With candidate permission, verified professional evidence can be reused, reducing repetitive assessments and improving discoverability.

Integrated execution. Q is not only a search bar; it coordinates recruiter approvals, interviews, assessments, communication and records.

Local and sector specialization. Deep playbooks for specific roles, languages, markets and employer workflows may create a strong initial reason to choose Talent Q.

Potential moats, once earned

Evidence network. A continuously maintained and permissioned graph of professional evidence may become hard to rebuild. **Outcome learning.** Carefully validated observations could improve relevance and reduce missed matches. **Workflow embedding.** Recruiter habits, integrations, team rubrics and prior candidate relationships can drive retention. **Distribution partnerships.** Licensed data, professional associations and employer networks can improve lawful supply.

At concept stage, these are future possibilities rather than assets already possessed. LinkedIn, Greenhouse, Juicebox and hireEZ already have significant product capability and distribution. Our credibility must come from execution and evidence, not from claiming a magic model or a market nobody else noticed.

Why now

Three forces align: AI is making applications easier to generate and harder to interpret; employers are investing in tools that reduce screening and administrative friction; and modern AI tools can handle conversation, retrieval and workflow coordination more affordably than before. [03][04][05][07] All three forces also help incumbents, making early focus and differentiation essential.

Why this team?

A credible founder/team slide or investor paragraph should describe actual recruitment-domain insight, product execution ability, security competence, distribution access and customer evidence. This brief deliberately does not invent named founders, prior exits, enterprise contracts or exclusive relationships. Those credentials should be added when verified, with the role each person plays in achieving the proposed milestones.

13. Risks, legal obligations and failure scenarios

Dependence on external talent data

Risk: LinkedIn does not permit unauthorized scraping or automation. Recruiter subscriptions are not blanket data-licensing agreements. [12] **Response:** Use candidate-owned profiles, employer records with appropriate permissions, licensed providers and approved connectors; test data economics.

Algorithmic hiring and bias

Risk: Hiring tools can affect livelihoods and can reproduce historical discrimination. **Response:** Use job-related criteria, human review, documented rubrics, accessibility, impact evaluations and challenge/correction routes.

Privacy and regulatory fragmentation

Risk: European recruitment-selection AI appears in AI Act Annex III as a high-risk category; the EU currently lists December 2027 as the application date for those high-risk obligations. [13][14] **Response:** Obtain qualified local advice, country-specific policies, consent records, traceability, incident response and audited deployment practices.

Automation replacing actual recruiter judgment

Risk: Companies may over-rely on an apparently authoritative score or transcript. **Response:** Scores are provisional aids; decisions require a legitimate human reviewer and source evidence.

Candidate trust

Risk: Unwanted outreach, social-media investigation and private interview reuse could drive users away. **Response:** Permissioned communication, minimized collection, visible sharing controls, deletion/correction, clear alternatives to video.

Unit costs and provider dependency

Risk: Sourcing licenses, voice sessions and premium video can overwhelm fixed subscription revenue. **Response:** Budget gates, usage caps, adapter architecture, metered add-ons, provider switching and full-bill monitoring.

Marketplace cold start

Risk: Employers want qualified candidates before paying; candidates want real jobs before joining. **Response:** Enter through paying employers and authorized existing talent pools; build candidate network from genuine demand.

Sales cycles and retention

Risk: Recruitment freezes or a one-time role can eliminate ongoing spend. **Response:** Target repeated hiring workflows and agencies, test mandates alongside subscriptions, measure cohort retention.

Weak predictive validity

Risk: Q-Match could perform no better than conventional screening. **Response:** Blind benchmark against rule-based baselines, measure false positives and decision quality, improve only when evidence supports it.

Security and misuse

Risk: Leaked CVs, forged credentials, compromised integrations or manipulated interviews could cause harm. **Response:** Strong tenant isolation, limited credentials, vetted content, monitoring, abuse controls, incident and deletion playbooks.

For Nigeria, section 37 of the Nigeria Data Protection Act addresses significant solely automated decisions and associated safeguards, including human intervention and the ability to contest. This requires legal and operational design review, not simply a disclosure checkbox. [15]

14. Development roadmap, evidence gates and operating milestones

Phase 0: technical and demand validation

Audit Q reuse boundaries and data isolation; interview prospective employers and candidates; confirm sourcing rights; define two role families, standard job rubrics and a measurable conventional recruiting baseline. No claim of proprietary algorithm performance should precede benchmark testing.

Phase 1: paid pilot, minimum complete journey

Build candidate and employer accounts, role intake, approved candidate import, retrieval, Q-Match baseline, reviewable shortlists, consented outreach, simple pipeline and recruiter dashboard. Run actual mandates end to end, including failures and refusals. The product is useful only if a qualified interested candidate can reach a recruiter decision.

Phase 2: structured interviews and candidate growth

Add text/voice screens, practical assessment orchestration, interview scheduling, candidate-owned reusable evidence, targeted practice and compliant feedback. Validate assessment reliability and candidate experience, particularly on older devices and weak networks.

Phase 3: recurring accounts and agents

Develop multi-user teams, agency client mandates, ATS/calendar integrations, persistent permission-scoped Q agents and metered usage. Focus on retention, gross margin and reliability rather than launching ten new unrelated products.

Phase 4: geographic and vertical expansion

Add countries and role families when legal readiness, data supply, buyer willingness and acquisition economics are proven. Publish an evidence-based talent matching methodology and maintain audit-ready evaluation results.

Key pilot targets proposed for validation

Gate	Suggested target / decision
Customer discovery	10–15 substantive employer/agency interviews plus candidate interviews.
Real hiring mandates	At least five instrumented recruitment pilots using real roles and documented baseline.
Commercial signal	Multiple paid pilots or contracts, then repeat usage and renewal.
Matching reliability	Blind shortlist reviews and comparison against simpler rule-based alternatives.
Candidate experience	Consent completion, interview drop-off, accessibility and meaningful status communication.
Delivery economics	Positive direct contribution per paid mandate/account with realistic support and provider charges.
Security and compliance	Permissions tests, documented data-source rights, legal review and issue response readiness.

Each target above is a proposed management gate, not a milestone already reached. Failed tests should change the product plan or the target customer, not be hidden by additional features.

15. What the investment would fund and what the investor should ask

The proposed investment story

Talent Q is seeking to establish whether a focused AI-native hiring system can deliver a better qualified-and-interested shortlist, lower recruiting effort and a more transparent candidate experience at sustainable cost. The tentative USD 1.8 million financing scenario funds engineering, pilots, lawful data access, evaluation, privacy, market development and runway contingency. This amount must be reworked after a monthly operating budget and verified founder commitments.

Diligence questions an investor should receive answers to

- Which exact customer segment buys first, and what does a buyer replace or stop paying for?
- How many real mandates have been completed, what did they cost and how did they compare with the previous process?
- What sources of candidate information are contractually and legally available in each target market?
- Which matching outputs are verified, and how is uncertainty represented to employers and candidates?
- What proportion of the shortlist accepts contact, proceeds to interview and receives an offer?
- How much does a full Q-led interview and specialist assessment actually cost with support included?
- What is the monthly cash-burn plan, runway, expected dilution and alternative financing if milestones take longer?
- Who owns the IP and customer relationships, and what roles are filled by the founding team?
- What prevents a large competitor from including a similar workflow in an existing subscription?
- What customer proof would cause management to double down, and what failure would cause a pivot or stop?

The close

A fundable next step is a live, evidence-backed Talent Q demo on a real but properly permissioned hiring mandate, alongside signed or paid pilot commitments, a transparent cost report and a benchmark against existing recruiting methods. The investment case becomes convincing when a first-time reader can see not only what Q can do, but why employers pay, why candidates participate, and why each completed mandate makes the product more useful.

> **FINAL PROPOSITION**
> **Talent Q aims to make hiring a decision supported by evidence and mutual interest, not a contest of who can generate or screen the most resumes. The next milestone is proof that this produces better outcomes at a cost customers will repeatedly pay.**

16. Source register and research boundaries

Public links were checked during preparation on 26 October 2026. Company product descriptions are vendor claims; market numbers are third-party estimates; research statistics reflect the specified respondent populations. Source access and product terms can change.

[01] Fortune Business Insights. Online Recruitment Technology Market, updated Sep 28 2026.
https://www.fortunebusinessinsights.com/online-recruitment-market-103730

[02] Grand View Research. AI Recruitment Market (2026–2035), published 2026.
https://www.grandviewresearch.com/industry-analysis/ai-recruitment-market-report

[03] SHRM. 2026 Talent Trends, Apr 27 2026; survey methodology in release.
https://www.shrm.org/about/press-room/shrm-unveils-2026-talent-trends-report--data-driven-insights-for

[04] Greenhouse. Future of Hiring Candidate Report announcement, Oct 20 2026.
https://www.greenhouse.com/newsroom/6-in-10-job-seekers-are-rethinking-how-they-write-to-avoid-sounding-like-ai-even-as-most-use-it-in-their-search

[05] LinkedIn. Hiring Assistant 2 announcement, Sep 29 2026.
https://news.linkedin.com/2026/hiring-assistant-2

[06] Indeed. Sourcing Assistant announcement, Jun 15 2026.
https://www.indeed.com/news/releases/indeeds-ai-powered-sourcing-assistant-helps-employers-hire-over-30-faster

[07] Greenhouse. Orchestrated Hiring Ecosystem launch, Oct 15 2026.
https://www.greenhouse.com/blog/introducing-the-orchestrated-hiring-ecosystem

[08] Juicebox. AI recruiting agents product documentation, accessed Oct 2026.
https://juicebox.ai/agents

[09] hireEZ. AI recruitment platform documentation, accessed Oct 2026.
https://hireez.com/platform/

[10] Jobberman Nigeria. Employer listings and recruitment service pricing, accessed Oct 2026.
https://www.jobberman.com/employer

[11] MyJobMag. Employer packages and AI matching features, accessed Oct 2026.
https://www.myjobmag.com/employers/

[12] LinkedIn Help. Prohibited software and extensions, accessed Oct 2026.
https://www.linkedin.com/help/linkedin/answer/a1341387/prohibition-of-scraping-software?lang=en

[13] EU AI Act Service Desk. Annex III: high-risk employment and recruitment uses.
https://ai-act-service-desk.ec.europa.eu/en/ai-act/annex-3

[14] European Commission. EU AI Act implementation timeline, accessed Oct 2026.
https://ai-act-service-desk.ec.europa.eu/en/ai-act/eu-ai-act-implementation-timeline

[15] Nigeria Data Protection Act 2023, section 37 (text reproduction).
https://lawcarenigeria.com/nigeria-data-protection-act-2023/

Outstanding research work

Before any investor-facing claim of traction or a predictive moat, Talent Q needs completed primary interviews, real contract pricing for candidate data providers, direct source licensing review, authenticated competitor workflow tests, real candidate testing, legal opinions where deployed, measured provider billing, a month-by-month cash model and a validation study. Desk research does not substitute for those activities. Legal discussion throughout is a design consideration, not legal advice.

> **THE DECISION AHEAD**
>
> **Support a disciplined proof-of-value program: real hiring mandates, willing candidates, lawful data access, independently checked matching quality, repeat paying customers and bounded delivery costs. If those results hold, Talent Q has an investment case grounded in evidence rather than promises.**